EITRAVELEDIT

Travel Radio Australia and we're here at the International Golf Travel Market in Khan in France and I've run into Keith McDonald from the EI Travel Group in Ireland and they do tours and all around Ireland to most of the major golf courses and some of the minor ones too. Keith, welcome to the program. Thank you Jeff.

It's great to speak to you and you've got that fabulous gravelly radio voice, you should be in radio yourself. Thanks yeah, maybe not television but radio would work I think. Keith, tell us about your company.

You were telling me before that it's really great because you can transport people all around Ireland and host them and do all sorts of things. Yeah, so we kind of wear two hats when I come to these shows. We're a transport provider so we've a fleet of 50 various sized buses everything from Audi Q8 all the way up to 94 seaters.

People come to me and travel agents to our operators worldwide and they just asking for the transport okay and then other people come to me and they look for our DMC services so we do everything from meet and greet to book in your hotels, book in your tea times, book in a tasting of whiskey on the ninth hole in Port Marnak. So we do everything from start to finish so we kind of sit down try to understand their customer before they get here so we know exactly what they want when they get here and try to make that journey when they arrive in Ireland as seamless as possible. EI Travel, how did it start? Did you start with just one bus or something? Tell us the story.

Yeah yeah I started with one bus which we still have it was a nine-seater it's called Boswell and I know the Australians will know the name Boswell because it comes from an Australian book called the Dunked in Tales which you might have read when you're younger and that was a mole it was a traveling mole that was based in Australia so we named the bus that we still have it it's 30 years old now that bus. We always kind of refer to it as like the Ravens at the Tower of London if the Ravens leave the Tower of London the whole Empire is going to collapse so that's why we're not getting rid of it. The expansion is incredible you were telling me you have up to 150 staff now it's a pretty big operation.

Yeah it is like the company started off as Extreme Ireland we were a climbing company. I was an international mountain guide for 20 years and I tried to gonna emulate what we did in the Alps back in Ireland. Unfortunately people don't come to Ireland to do that level of climbing so I had to diversify we went into daytours in about 2009 which exploded in Ireland because new motorways allowed people in Dublin to travel over to the West Coast of Ireland one day so we carry about 300,000 people here on that side of the business.

We all to do leisure we do FIT we do full multi-day itineraries. In 2014 I opened the Irish whisky

museum which is an independent visitor attraction in the city centre directly opposite Trinity College and we cater for about a hundred thousand people here telling people about the history of Irish whisky. In 2019 we set up cityside team Dublin which is the hop on hop off business in Dublin the red buses which are recognizable worldwide and then in 2024 we open a new visitor attraction called the world of illusion and so we imply about 150 in various different apartments everything from mechanics to guides to drivers to markets to sales we're constantly looking at new projects okay and that's why I never ever gonna be rich because I just keep spending money on new projects unfortunately so we're working on a project at the moment which we're calling ocean era which is going to be a massive aquarium in Dublin I think it's something that Dublin needs I think it's something that Ireland needs and we're looking at working with our government him on funding the project because it's gonna cost about a hundred million euro but it's gonna be a world-class visitor attraction and it's gonna show the connection that Irish people have with our waters around us we're an island nation.

That's an incredible amount of projects you have on the go and you piqued my interest with the world of illusion because I am actually a professional magician as well and tell me about that what's that all about? So it's very close to Trinity College in Dublin it was an attraction that we wanted to for everybody okay for families like in Dublin as you're aware there's a lot of alcohol based attractions there's very little for families to do in Dublin and we wanted to create something so we actually see in the Museum of Illusions which is a franchise around Europe mostly and we visited them we talked to them and then we came back and said you know what we can actually do better ourselves and we wanted to make a unique proposition so we've got about 85 illusions in the building but they're all related to Ireland okay so they could be Dublin characters like Oscar Wilde's but every door that you walk through is going to be a Georgian door that replicates the buildings in South Dublin so we wanted to make a difference and yeah you can go to Museum of Illusions anywhere in the world and they're going to be the same okay so we worked with magicians like yourself on the illusions so it takes roughly if you're with a family it takes you up to two hours okay to get through it as I said it's very little for families to do in Dublin except go to museums which the kids are really not interested in but the demographics is quite different than the whisky museum whereas whisky museum and ei travel will get over 90% international customers in the world of illusion we get 80% international them we get 80% domestic in the world of illusion yeah so it's for everybody okay you know you've got nothing to do you're with your partner or your parents you could be on a stag party you could have a few hours in Dublin and I suppose what we look at is what we got edutainment yeah we want to educate you true entertainment okay so all of you it's not rocket science what we want to do is give you something that you're gonna leave and have a smile on your face and you're gonna have to learn on something it's an incredible concept and I mean magic is becoming really popular around the world in the last 20 years and especially with fantastic facilities like yours you told me about one of your plans and and do you have a couple more in the pipeline leave a couple more in the pipeline we're looking at work in bringing the river in the river Liffey which flows through the middle of Dublin we're looking at potentially putting a new boat on the river itself I think Dublin

Bay and the Liffey River is very underutilized compared to a lot of other cities I mean you go over to London the Thames just boats everywhere you go to Amsterdam boats everywhere Dublin just one boat and that's it you know it's bananas you know I'm like so we're trying to create something new in Dublin for people to do like there's lots of things to do in Dublin the museums are amazing the Guinness Store house Jamison all them are brilliant attractions but we need to create more okay we want to see 10 million visitors come to Dublin by 2013 okay and we need things to offer them that they're gonna remember okay and we want to with the ocean area that we're building we want to build similar to Sydney Opera House we want to build an iconic structure but it has to be function as a proper aquarium okay so we have traveled all over the world actually and only back from Monterey which we thought was probably the best aquarium we visit it because it's gonna be a lot about sustainability okay it's gonna be a lot about education there's also gonna be an animal sanctuary as well but we want to create an iconic building that people remember if you're flying into Dublin you're gonna see it from the sky okay and people are gonna want to just go to that building and then they're going to visit an aquarium which is an amazing buildings it's a sustainable project we're sourcing all the fish from different aquariums and nothing is coming from the ocean at all like aquariums are really good for your mental well-being as well there's a lot of research done on people that go to them and for special needs people and it comes people okay and we want to educate people about the future of our worlds and what we need to do to protect the waters for our future generations now I'm speaking with Keith McDonald from EI travel group they were into so many things in Ireland and I always ask this can you give us something that does a bit off the beaten track in Dublin to do as a local there that you would really recommend a tourist that maybe want something super authentic no I'm hoping this is not gonna have the opposite effects okay my local pub is called the blue light pub okay it's an authentic mountain pub tourists don't go there because there's no buses that go up there it's on a really small road it's only 30 minutes about city it's got the most amazing view down over Dublin city so if you wanted a real attempt to get now they're mountain people that live up there that drink up there they're not gonna bite you don't worry about it don't put you'll have an amazing time and it does if not the best point to how can people find out more online Keith yeah so our website is www.eitravelgroup.ie if you're coming you want us to plan a trip for you your family or friends that's the website to go through that's the DMC site if you're just arriving yourself you're maybe only staying for the weekends you might want to do a day tour so go to irisdaytours.ie okay iriswhiskeymuseum.ie is there whiskey museum and world of illusion.ie is that but if you go to eitravelgroup.ie that will point you in the right direction of all our other attractions great thanks very much and welcome to Khan and it's been great talking to you thank you Jeff